people from your economy. [According to estimates I'd seen, something like four hundred thousand to five hundred thousand Jews wanted to leave the Soviet Union.] I can see where this could present problems. These people are part of your society and many of them must have important jobs. But did it ever occur to you, on this whole question of human rights, that maybe if these Jews were permitted to worship as they want to and teach their children the Hebrew language, that maybe they wouldn't want to leave the Soviet Union?

"That's how our country was started, by people who were not allowed to worship as they wished in their homeland, so they came to our shores, a wilderness across the Atlantic, and founded our nation. I'm sure a lot of your people who are asking to leave wouldn't want to leave if they had freedom of religion. They say they want to leave, but they're Russians. I know they must love their country as much as other Russians do, so perhaps if they were allowed to reopen their synagogues and worship as they want to, they might decide that they wouldn't have to leave and there wouldn't be that problem of a brain drain."

I said Americans were very encouraged by the changes occurring in the Soviet Union and hoped the changes would soon be institutionalized as laws under the Soviet system. And, for all the changes that Gorbachev had made, I said, wouldn't it be a good idea to tear down the Berlin Wall? Nothing in the West symbolized the differences between it and the Soviet Union more than the wall, I said; its removal would be seen as a gesture symbolizing that the Soviet Union wanted to join the broader community of nations.

Well, Gorbachev listened and seemed to take in my opinions; from his expression I knew he didn't like some of the things I was saying, but he didn't try to say anything harsh in rebuttal. Whether my words had any impact or not I don't know, but after that the Soviet government began